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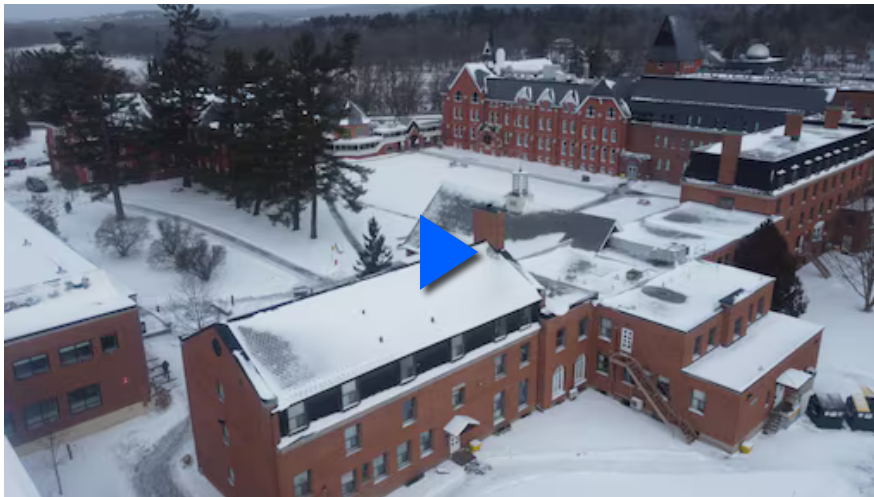
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# Bishop's students allege teacher uses degrading terms, university doing nothing

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Students at Bishop's University allege a professor has been using derogatory language in her classroom for years.

Students at Bishop's University in Sherbrooke, Que., say they're shocked and appalled by the school's apparent lack of action over a teacher they allege has been using derogatory language in her classroom for years.

Several students have reached out to CTV News to express their concerns and demand that sociology professor Dr. Cheryl Gosselin change her ways.

"She just has her own biases when it comes to teaching. For example, there was a moment in which she was talking about how Black women 'react' and how she didn't really like Black women," said sociology student Malik Kessouagni, who says he's taken three classes with Gosselin. "She was staring straight at a Black woman that was in her class at that moment. So, that was honestly kind of rough."

He alleges that she also singled him out when talking about stereotypes.

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"The stereotype about Black men with large penises and all that and stared at both me and one of my friends as we were the only Black people there," Kessouagni said.

Sociology student Marie-May Lamothe says she not only remembers these incidents but claims she also witnessed Gosselin allegedly using discriminatory words when discussing the LGBTQIA2S+ community as recently as last November.

"She said the 'F' slur," she said. "When she said it, she said it many times. She said it at least six or seven times, and there was an audible gasp from the classroom."

During that class, political science student Aaliyah Wilburn says she tried to ask Gosselin to consider the repercussions of using such strong language.

"She basically blew me off. Told me I was incorrect, and basically, she made me feel dumb for saying something," she said.

Kessouagni says he also remembers that incident.

"Her defence was it's not a word that she uses on a daily basis," he said. "In my opinion, regardless of the fact if you use it on a daily basis or not, you still used it. Therefore, it's still an issue and you do not want to hold yourself accountable."

Unsatisfied with Gosselin's justification, Wilburn says she reached out to the university's Equity, Diversity and Inclusion (EDI) department.

"It just felt like they were trying to find reasons and excuses for why Cheryl was saying the things that she was saying, when really there is no context that you need to have with it," she said. "There is no excuse that you need to have with it. Like, you said what you said; hold your teachers accountable."

Lamothe adds throughout the course of her time in Gosselin's class, she also allegedly misgendered non-binary authors, called Arab men sexist and argued that women who wear the hijab "slut shame" Caucasian women.

She says Gosselin freely used the 'N' word and the 'F' slur when discussing readings or lectures about the Black and LGBTQIA+ communities.

"She used it in a such a derogatory manner. She used it like it had no meaning," said Lamothe. "Especially in a class where there are queer students...that word is really powerful."

Lamothe says she ultimately chose to drop the class.

"I have better things to do," she said matter-of-factly.



Bishop's University in Sherbrooke, Que. (Renée Lavoie/Noovo Info)

On [ratemyprofessor.com](https://www.ratemyprofessor.com), Gosselin has mixed reviews, with one student from 2015 writing, "I spoke with her about some discriminatory language that she used often during her lectures and she basically said I had no right to feel offended because it was 'the language of the time.'"

Another from 2006 argues, "[portrays] French people as crazy people who spend [their] days trying to assimilate English. At the same time, very helpful and very available for her students."

The students CTV News spoke to insist the most disturbing part of the whole debacle is Gosselin's alleged lack of sympathy when they say they asked her for sensitivity.

"She kind of just was like, 'I don't really care,' even with her using the 'F' slur, she wasn't really apologetic or regretful about her actions," said sociology student Rory Point-Du-Jour, who says she took a class with Gosselin in 2022. "She was just like, 'you guys kind of just have to deal with it,' like it is what it is."

She says she chose not to drop the class but adds she felt uncomfortable for the rest of the semester.

"Being a teacher there, you already are aware of the lack of minorities who are there," she said. "You're making them feel even more uncomfortable by making it seem like it's OK to use that word."

Point-Du-Jour says it's also about setting an example for the students.

"A white student may be like, 'OK, if my professor is saying this, I should be able to say it too,'" she said. "It's almost confusing in the sense that you would think that we've gotten so far in society, and then to have this teacher still using these derogatory terms so freely in a classroom is just really appalling."



Bishop's University in Sherbrooke, Que. (Renée Lavoie/Noovo Info)

The Bishop's University Students' Representative Council (SRC) says it is not aware of any formal complaints against Gosselin, "nor have any students brought such concerns to our attention."

"We encourage anyone who feels their concerns are not being addressed to reach out to the appropriate channels at the university," the council said, offering its support. "If students are experiencing issues in the classroom, we recommend that they contact the

Office of the Dean or another relevant administrative office directly to file a formal report." In addition, Bishop's University says it "cannot comment, discuss or disclose any confidential or personal information," adding that it "holds itself and its faculty and staff to the highest standards."

"If concerns are raised or allegations are brought to our attention about one of our community members, we act swiftly and go to great lengths to review the facts, follow due process, and determine if the allegations bear any truth," said Sonia Patenaude, communications manager at the university. "Moreover, we encourage and support members of our community witnessing or experiencing improper behaviour to report it."

Refusing to discuss Gosselin specifically, she notes the university has both formal and informal processes for student complaints.

All the same, Lamothe insists she wants to see Bishop's University do something to protect its students from further potential discrimination.

"If you're teaching a class as sensitive as gender in society, you cannot go on with saying slander and misinformation when this is such a sensitive topic in today's political environment," she argues. "She needs to face a real repercussion and realize that this is an actual incident that means a lot, and you can hurt a lot of people, and I think she needs to face that."

CTV News reached out to Cheryl Gosselin for comment on the allegations. She did not respond.

Following multiple subsequent exchanges with Bishop's University in an attempt to reach Gosselin, CTV News was told, "We, or anyone from our community, cannot and will not comment, discuss or disclose information to the accusations or allegations you are referring to."

The university goes on to say, "Open dialogue and constructive debate are encouraged, while maintaining a safe and respectful environment," including a link to their [policy on academic freedom](#).

Quebec's Higher Education Ministry called the allegations "worrying."

"Our universities are places of debate where all subjects, even the most sensitive, must be discussed, but this must always be done respectfully. Discriminatory comments cannot be tolerated," said ministry spokesperson Simon Savignac. "Remember that there are provisions in place under the Academic Freedom Act, and we invite the students concerned to lodge a complaint through the official channels."

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